

LIGHT MACHINE-GUNS (1966–PRESENT)

Modern light machine-guns are either gas- or recoil-operated. They continue to be characterized by their extensive use of plastic or resin-impregnated components, stamped parts, and light weight. With a few exceptions, they are designed for individual use to provide squad support fire. Increasingly they have been fitted with optical sights to improve their effectiveness in the field. While the Gatling Minigun was intended for use from a fixed mount, its short overall length qualifies it as a light machine-gun.



▲ GATLING MINIGUN M134
Date 1960s
Origin US
Barrel 22in (56cm)
Caliber 7.62 × 51mm NATO

The M134 is a Gatling-type rotary weapon that is powered by an electric motor to achieve extremely high rates of fire—up to 6,000 rounds per minute, although typically the rate is limited to around 4,000 rounds per minute. The weight and bulk of the external power source mean that the gun is usually used in helicopters, on armored vehicles, or on boats.



▲ PKM
Date 1969
Origin Soviet Union
Barrel 25¼in (64cm)
Caliber 7.62 × 54mm

A General-Purpose Machine-Gun (GPMG), the PKM is gas-operated, belt-fed, and air-cooled. Its rate of fire is around 650–750 rounds per minute. It is an improved variant of the Mikhail Kalashnikov-designed PK. Its butt plate is hinged.



► FN MINIMI
Date 1975
Origin Belgium
Barrel 18¼in (46.5cm)
Caliber 5.56 × 45mm NATO

An outstanding gas-operated, air-cooled light machine-gun, the Minimi has a rate of fire of around 700–1,150 rounds per minute. It was adopted by the British Army and the US Army, among others. In the US Army, it was designated the M249 Squad Automatic Weapon (SAW).